

Green Keel-Bellied Lizard (*Gastropholis prasina*)

Difficulty: Intermediate

Green keel-bellied lizards are medium-sized (10-14" long) diurnal lizards known for their vibrant green or turquoise coloration. They have slender bodies with tapered snouts, rectangular scales, and long toes perfectly adapted for an arboreal lifestyle. Unlike many smaller geckos, these are proficient climbers that spend the majority of their time in the forest canopy.

Native to the coastal forests of Kenya and Tanzania, these lizards are active during the day and are prized for being lively, entertaining display animals. While their exact maximum lifespan in captivity is still being documented, they are hardy when provided with specialized care.

Shopping List

- 36" x 18" x 36" (Minimum) vertical arboreal terrarium
- T5 HO UVB Lighting (Arcadia or Zoo Med)
- Reflector fixture (Arcadia or Vivarium Electronics)
- 2x Halogen heat bulbs (for a heat cluster)
- Dual dome lamp or individual ceramic sockets
- 6500K LED or T5 grow light (for plants and visibility)
- Pressure sprayer or misting system
- Digital thermometer/hygrometer with probes
- 2-4" Tropical substrate (Eco Earth, ReptiSoil, or Jungle Mix)
- Arboreal Decor (Branches, cork hollows, vines, and foliage)
- Feeding platform with cups
- Feeding tongs
- Calcium & Multivitamin supplement (e.g., Repashy Calcium Plus LoD)

Housing

Green keel-bellied lizards are highly active and arboreal. The absolute minimum enclosure size for a single adult is 36"L x 18"W x 36"H. Because they are a social species, they can be housed in groups, but you must increase the enclosure size accordingly.

- Note: Never house multiple males together, and avoid keeping males and females together unless you are prepared for breeding.

Lighting & UVB

Unlike crepuscular geckos, Green keel-bellied lizards require high-quality UVB lighting for survival. It facilitates vitamin D3 synthesis, strengthens the immune system, and aids digestion.

- Arcadia T5 HO 6% / Zoo Med 5.0: Mount 6-8" above the basking branch.
- Arcadia T5 HO 12% / Zoo Med 10.0: Mount 12-14" above the basking branch.

Pro Tip: These lizards often climb on the ceiling mesh. Prop the UVB fixture 1-2" above the mesh using blocks to prevent "sunburn" or overexposure if the lizard hangs directly under the screen. Lights should be on a 12-hour cycle.

Heating

Green keel-bellied lizards are cold-blooded and require a thermal gradient to regulate their metabolism. Sunlight is best replicated using a cluster of at least two halogen heat bulbs to create a wide basking zone.

- Basking area temperature: 90°F
- Ambient temperature: 70-80°F
- Night temperature: 65-70°F

The basking area should be a sturdy branch positioned at the appropriate distance from your UVB and Heat lamps. Use digital probe thermometers to ensure the basking spot doesn't fluctuate into dangerous levels. Turn all heat sources off at night.

Humidity

As a tropical species, they require a high average humidity of 60-80%. Use a pressure sprayer to mist the enclosure 1-2 times daily—once in the morning and once at night. This mimics dewfall and provides the lizards with droplets to drink from.

- Water Quality: Use conditioned tap water (Reptisafe) to ensure your lizard receives trace minerals while removing harmful chlorine/chloramines.

Substrate

While these lizards are arboreal, a naturalistic substrate is essential for maintaining humidity. Use a moisture-retaining mix like Zoo Med ReptiSoil or Exo Terra Plantation Soil.

- Drainage: For bioactive or heavily misted setups, consider a drainage layer of clay balls (Hydroton) beneath the soil.
- Leaf Litter: Add a thick layer of clean, chemical-free leaf litter on top of the soil to further boost humidity and provide a natural aesthetic.

Spot clean daily and perform a full substrate change every 3-4 months.

Food

Green keel-bellied lizards are primarily insectivores. They are visual hunters and enjoy chasing live prey. While insects are the staple, they can occasionally be offered high-quality Crested Gecko Diet (CGD) as a treat.

- Main Staples: Dubia roaches, crickets, silkworms, and black soldier fly larvae.
- Occasional Treats: Hornworms, mealworms, and CGD.

Feeding Schedule:

- Juveniles: Feed daily.
- Adults: Feed 2-3 times per week.
- Method: Offer as many insects as they can eat in 5 minutes via tongs or a feeding ledge.

Supplements

All feeder insects should be "dusted" with a high-quality supplement. Repashy Calcium Plus LoD is an excellent all-in-one choice for species kept under UVB. It provides the necessary calcium and vitamins without overdoing the D3 content.

Decor

An empty cage leads to a stressed, bored lizard. Because they are arboreal, the vertical space must be filled. Use a variety of:

- Vines and Branches: Different diameters to exercise their feet.

- Foliage: Live plants (like Pothos or Schefflera) or silk plants to provide hiding spots.
- Ledges: Magnetic or suction-cup ledges help maximize the "usable" square footage of the glass walls.

Hot Tip: Handling

Green keel-bellied lizards are generally "display only" pets. They are fast and can be flighty. While they aren't typically aggressive, they do not "enjoy" being held. The best way to bond with them is through tong-feeding, which helps them associate your presence with positive rewards without the stress of physical restraint.